BUILD WHAT PAYS

A SOLO BUILDER'S FIELD MANUAL FOR FINDING IDEAS THAT PAY

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A Solo Builder's Field Manual
for Finding Ideas That Pay

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Introduction

Most builders do not fail because they cannot execute. They fail because they choose weak ideas, validate too late, and confuse interest with demand.

They mistake motion for evidence. They generate long lists of plausible products, follow whatever is trending, or fall in love with a tool before they have earned a problem. Then they spend weeks or months building something that never had enough pain, urgency, or spending behind it to matter.

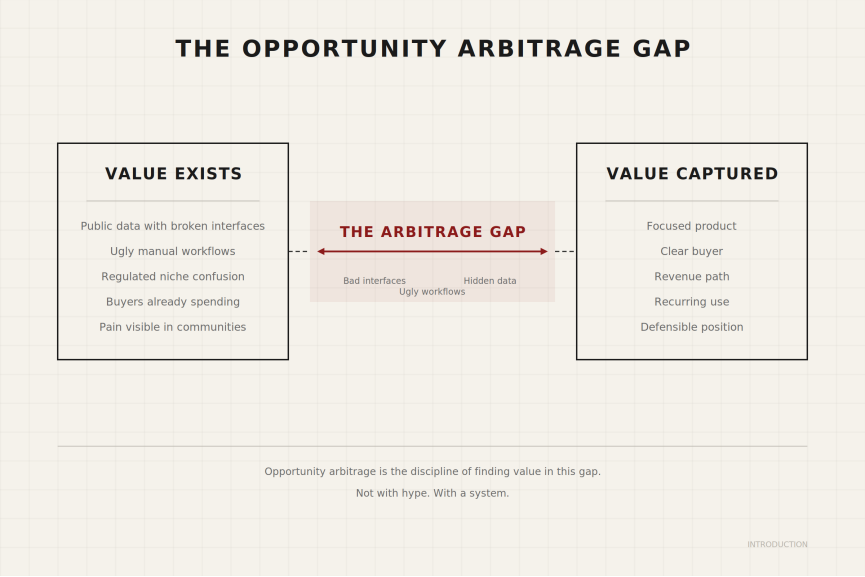
That is the trap.

The market leaks signal everywhere. Operators complain about ugly workflows in forums. Small businesses pay monthly for software they resent. Public data sits in broken interfaces with zero packaging and obvious commercial value. Buyers reveal intent through permits, licenses, inspections, filings, violations, complaints, recalls, and other operational signals long before most founders notice.

Opportunity arbitrage is the discipline of finding value in that gap.

Not with hype. Not with generic "AI startup ideas." Not with another brainstorm dump.

With a system.



A strong solo-builder opportunity usually has some combination of these traits:

- a clear buyer
- a painful, repeated problem
- visible money already changing hands
- a narrow version that can ship fast
- a believable path to first revenue
- enough defensibility to matter, without so much complexity that the build collapses under its own ambition

The goal is not to find the most glamorous idea. The goal is to find the strongest wedge.

This book will help you do three things:

1. find higher-signal opportunities

2. kill weak ideas faster
3. validate before you overbuild

The first half gives you the framework. The second half shows you what strong wedges look like in practice. The appendices give you scorecards and worksheets you can use immediately.

If this book works, it should make you more ruthless. Ruthless about what counts as evidence. Ruthless about what gets cut. Ruthless about what deserves your next 30 days.

Why This Book

I did not build this framework because I wanted a cleaner way to brainstorm.

I built it because I got tired of watching smart builders waste time on weak bets.

My working life has been shaped by operations, sequencing, constraints, and consequence. I spent more than twenty years in construction project management, where vague thinking gets expensive fast. On a real project, you do not get points for interesting ideas. You get measured on whether the thing works, whether the timing holds, whether the budget survives contact with reality, and whether the risks were visible early enough to matter. That operating instinct came with me into software, automation, data products, and AI-assisted builds.

The pattern showed up immediately.

Builders were not short on ideas. They were drowning in them. Every trend produced another wave of "maybe this could be a startup" energy. Every new model or tool created another excuse to go hunting for a problem after the solution already felt exciting. Every founder

thread became another reminder that the market rewards judgment more than ideation, but almost nobody was building systems for judgment.

So I started scoring opportunities harder.

Not in a theoretical way. In a practical, repetitive, operator way. Who is the buyer? How painful is the problem? Is money already moving? Is the trigger obvious? Can the first version ship without drowning in complexity? Is there a believable path to distribution, or am I lying to myself because the build sounds fun?

I have evaluated more than two hundred opportunities this way. Most of them failed the filters.

That is the point.

A good framework should reject more ideas than it advances. If it blesses everything, it is not a framework. It is a mood board.

Some of those rejected opportunities were technically interesting. Some lived in large markets. Some sounded smart in conversation. Some were even directionally right but still too early, too broad, too vague, or too dependent on wishful distribution. A few survived. Fewer still earned the right to become projects worth building around.

That process changed how I work.

Instead of asking, "What should I build?" I started asking better questions.

Where is money already leaking? Where is the workflow ugly? Where is the buyer under time pressure? Where is the data valuable but unusable? Where can I get to first proof without pretending I need a full product before I can learn anything real?

This book came out of those repetitions.

It is not a memoir. It is not a victory lap. It is not a claim that every wedge here is a winner. It is a compressed system built from seeing

the same failure modes over and over: novelty bias, vague buyers, no trigger, no path to money, too much software before proof, and founders mistaking their own excitement for market reality.

If you use this book well, it will probably save you from building a few things you currently like.

Good.

That is cheaper than building them.

CHAPTER 1

The Idea Trap

Most builders think their job starts with ideas. It does not. It starts with filters.

An unfiltered idea pipeline produces junk. You can make almost anything sound plausible if you stay abstract enough: a marketplace for X, an AI assistant for Y, a dashboard for Z. Plausibility is cheap. The market does not pay for plausibility.

Weak ideas usually survive for the same reasons.

NOVELTY BIAS

Builders chase what feels new, not what is painful. A clever product gets more attention in founder circles than a boring product that solves a recurring operational headache.

PROXIMITY BIAS

Builders overvalue problems they personally find interesting, even when the buyer is unclear or the budget is weak.

TOOL-FIRST THINKING

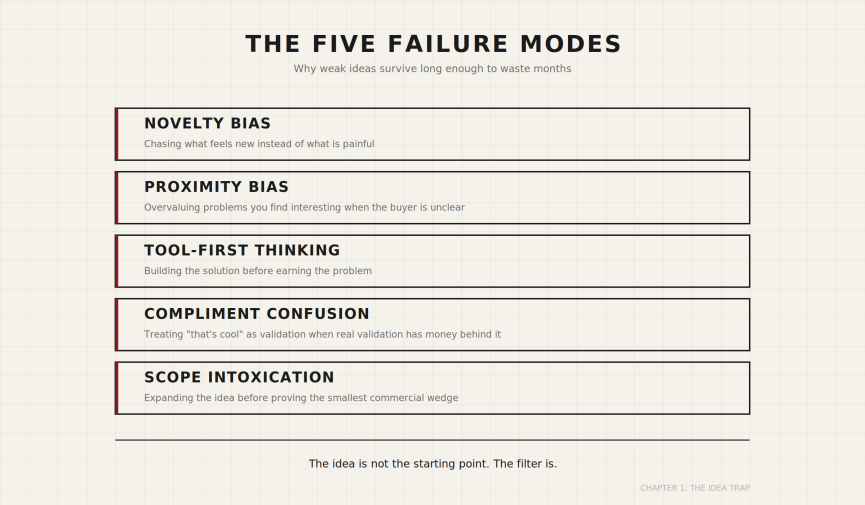
AI, scraping, automation, agents, and workflows become excuses to go looking for a problem after the solution already feels exciting.

COMPLIMENT CONFUSION

People say, "That's cool," or, "I'd use that," and founders treat it like validation. It is not. Real validation has cost, effort, urgency, or money behind it.

SCOPE INTOXICATION

The idea sounds big enough to matter, so the founder expands it before proving the smallest commercial wedge.



The result is predictable: months of work, weak demand, and a stack of explanations for why the market just was not ready.

Good founders are not just idea generators. They are idea editors. They know how to cut.

CHAPTER 2

The Money-First Lens

A money-first lens does not mean greed-first. It means evidence-first.

The strongest early signal is not, "People care about this topic." It is, "People are already paying, losing money, or burning serious time because this problem is unresolved."

There are three especially strong signals.

CURRENT SPENDING

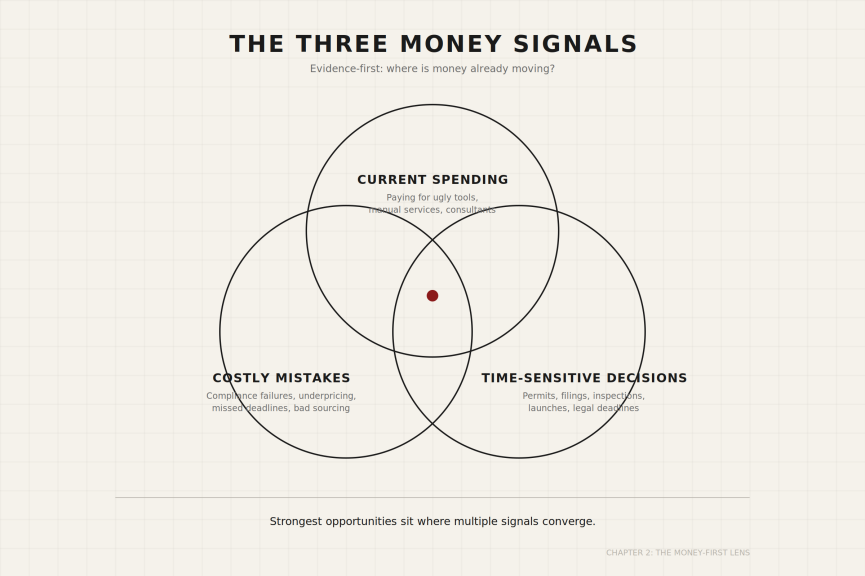
If people already pay for an ugly tool, a manual service, a consultant, an attorney, or a spreadsheet-heavy process, there is usually room to build something sharper.

COSTLY MISTAKES

Markets with repeated errors, compliance failures, underpricing, missed deadlines, bad sourcing, or weak tracking create stronger purchase intent than markets full of casual wish lists.

TIME-SENSITIVE DECISIONS

If a buyer needs the answer now because of a permit, launch, filing, inspection, deadline, or legal risk, urgency compresses the sales cycle.



A money-first builder asks:

- What are they already paying for?
- What mistakes are currently costing them money?
- What ugly process are they tolerating because nothing better exists?
- Can software, AI, or automation collapse this pain enough to matter?

That is why small, specific markets so often beat broad inspirational categories. A reseller trying to survive tax season, a contractor trying to catch permits before competitors, or a food founder trying to launch legally has a stronger buying trigger than someone vaguely asking for better productivity.

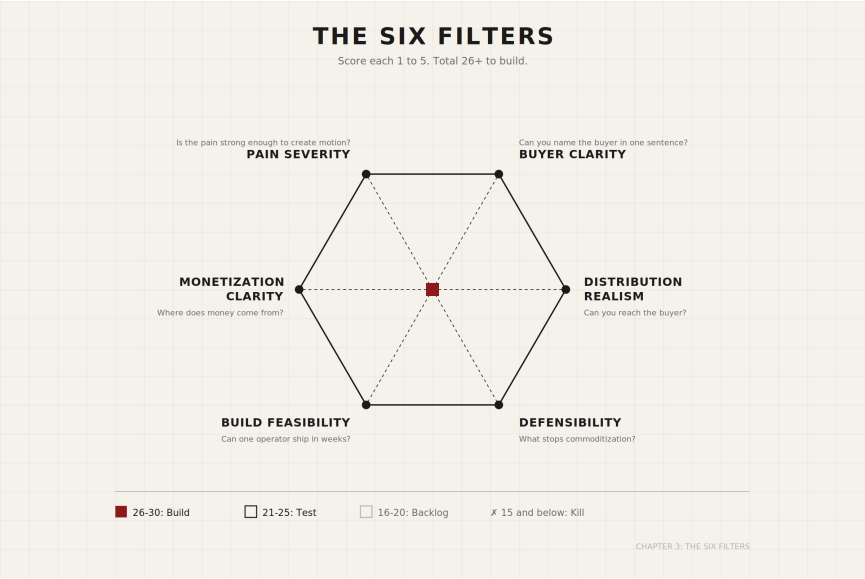
Specific pain creates specific products.

CHAPTER 3

The Six Filters

Most idea evaluation is too soft. Founders say things like "big market," "strong trend," or "interesting space." None of that is enough.

Use these six filters on every opportunity before you let yourself like it.



BUYER CLARITY

Can you name the buyer in one sentence?

Not "small businesses." Not "creators." Not "anyone who needs help with X."

A useful buyer definition sounds like this:

- first-time hot sauce entrepreneur trying to sell legally
- part-time reseller with tax-season spreadsheet chaos
- leather crafter underpricing custom commissions
- roofer who wants permit-triggered sales alerts in one county

If the buyer is fuzzy, the product will be fuzzy.

PAIN SEVERITY

Is the problem painful enough to create motion?

Strong pain usually does at least one of these things:

- costs money
- creates legal or compliance risk
- wastes significant time
- causes repeated operational mistakes
- blocks revenue
- creates public embarrassment or reputation damage

A mild inconvenience rarely converts. A recurring operational wound often does.

MONETIZATION CLARITY

How does this make money quickly and believably?

There should be a visible path to one of these:

- subscription
- lead generation

- affiliate or referral revenue
- premium alerts or reports
- setup or service revenue before software
- narrow B2B tool with obvious ROI

If the money story is vague, the idea is weaker than it feels.

BUILD FEASIBILITY

Can one operator get to proof without dying in complexity?

The question is not whether the idea can be built eventually. Nearly anything can. The question is whether the smallest wedge can ship in weeks, not quarters.

DEFENSIBILITY

If this works, what stops it from becoming a commodity?

Early defensibility does not need to mean a giant moat. It means there is something that gets harder to copy over time: curated data, workflow fit, niche trust, domain-specific scoring, or recurring operational use.

DISTRIBUTION REALISM

Do you have a believable path to the buyer?

A strong idea with weak access can still be a bad bet. If the distribution thesis is basically hope, the opportunity is not ready.

QUICK SCORECARD

Rate each opportunity from 1 to 5 on all six filters.

- **26–30:** strong build candidate
- **21–25:** good candidate, but pressure-test before committing
- **16–20:** backlog or tighten the wedge

- **15 and below:** kill unless new evidence appears

The point is not false precision. The point is forced judgment.

CHAPTER 4

Three Discovery Engines

Good opportunities tend to emerge from the same few mechanics. Once you understand the mechanics, you stop waiting for inspiration.

ENGINE 1: MONEY TRAILS IN COMMUNITIES

Look where people openly discuss:

- what they pay for
- what tools they hate
- what mistakes cost them money
- what manual work they are tired of doing
- what services they wish were better or cheaper

Good hunting grounds include subreddits, niche forums, Facebook groups, review sites for ugly vertical software, and practitioner-heavy YouTube comment sections.

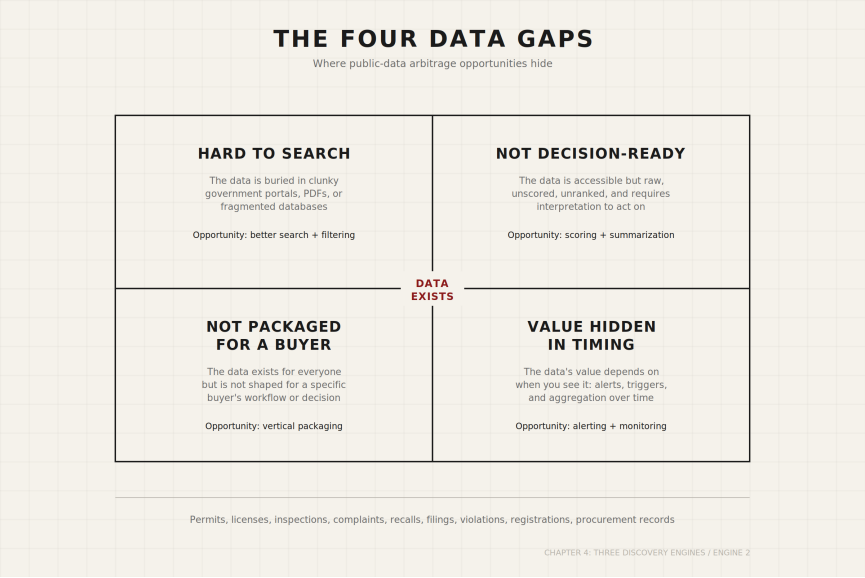
You are looking for evidence, not vibes.

ENGINE 2: PUBLIC-DATA ARBITRAGE

This engine works when valuable data exists but the interface is broken, the SEO is weak, or the commercial use case is hidden.

Look for data such as: permits, licenses, inspections, complaints, recalls, filings, violations, registrations, procurement records, and public performance metrics.

The opportunity usually sits in one of four gaps:



ENGINE 3: WORKFLOW COMPRESSION

Some markets still run on spreadsheets, copy-paste lookups, scattered vendor tabs, ad hoc checklists, inbox-and-memory project management, and brittle manual processes.

That is fertile ground.

A workflow-compression product does not need to be revolutionary. It needs to reduce steps, reduce mistakes, centralize context, save time, and make pricing, tracking, or compliance less fragile.

Most strong solo-builder products come from one engine or a combination of two. The point is to stop asking for ideas and start running engines.

CHAPTER 5

Kill Signals

A lot of progress comes from saying no faster.

Bad ideas do not fail quietly. They leak weakness early.

KILL SIGNAL CHECKLIST

Bad ideas leak weakness early. Check before you commit.

- [ ] **BUYER IS BLURRY**
  Cannot say exactly who this is for in one sentence
- [ ] **FEATURE, NOT PRODUCT**
  No standalone buying trigger; only works as an add-on
- [ ] **PATH TO MONEY IS HAND-WAVY**
  "Maybe ads," "maybe marketplace later" are not monetization plans
- [ ] **PAIN IS POLITE, NOT PAINFUL**
  No urgency, cost, embarrassment, or operational consequence
- [ ] **DISTRIBUTION IS WISHFUL**
  No believable path to the buyer beyond hope
- [ ] **WEDGE IS TOO BROAD**
  First version tries to serve the whole category
- [ ] **CANNOT REACH THE BUYER**
  Trust barriers, procurement cycles, or domain constraints block access
- [ ] **NEEDS TOO MUCH TO PROVE ANYTHING**
  Requires heavy infrastructure, integrations, or polished UX before validation
- [ ] **LEGALLY CONTAMINATED**
  Path depends on legal gray zones or high-liability behavior
- [ ] **EXCITED ABOUT TOOLING, NOT MARKET**
  The stack is the real draw, not the buyer's pain

Two or more checked = KILL or reshape the wedge

CHAPTER 5: KILL SIGNALS

THE BUYER IS BLURRY

If you cannot say exactly who this is for, the problem is not ready.

IT SMELLS LIKE A FEATURE, NOT A PRODUCT

If it only works as an add-on to a larger system and has no standalone buying trigger, it may not deserve to exist on its own.

THE PATH TO MONEY IS HAND-WAVY

"Maybe ads," "maybe marketplace later," and "maybe enterprise eventually" are not real monetization plans.

THE PAIN IS POLITE, NOT PAINFUL

If there is no urgency, cost, embarrassment, or operational consequence, move on.

DISTRIBUTION IS WISHFUL

If the distribution thesis is mostly hope, the opportunity is weaker than it looks.

THE WEDGE IS TOO BROAD

If the first version tries to serve everyone in a category, you are not choosing a wedge. You are avoiding the discipline of choosing.

YOU CANNOT REACH THE BUYER

A problem can be real and still be a bad bet if the buyer is behind trust barriers, long procurement cycles, or domain constraints you do not want to fight.

THE PRODUCT NEEDS TOO MUCH BEFORE IT CAN PROVE ANYTHING

If the wedge requires many integrations, polished UX, or heavy infrastructure before it can validate, that is a warning.

IT IS LEGALLY CONTAMINATED

Some opportunities are real but not worth the exposure. If the path depends on legal gray zones or high-liability behavior, cut it.

YOU ARE EXCITED MAINLY BECAUSE THE TOOLING IS FUN

If the best argument for the idea is that the stack is interesting, the market is probably not the real driver.

The strongest founders are not the ones who discover the most opportunities. They are the ones who kill weak opportunities before those opportunities eat six months of energy.

CHAPTER 6

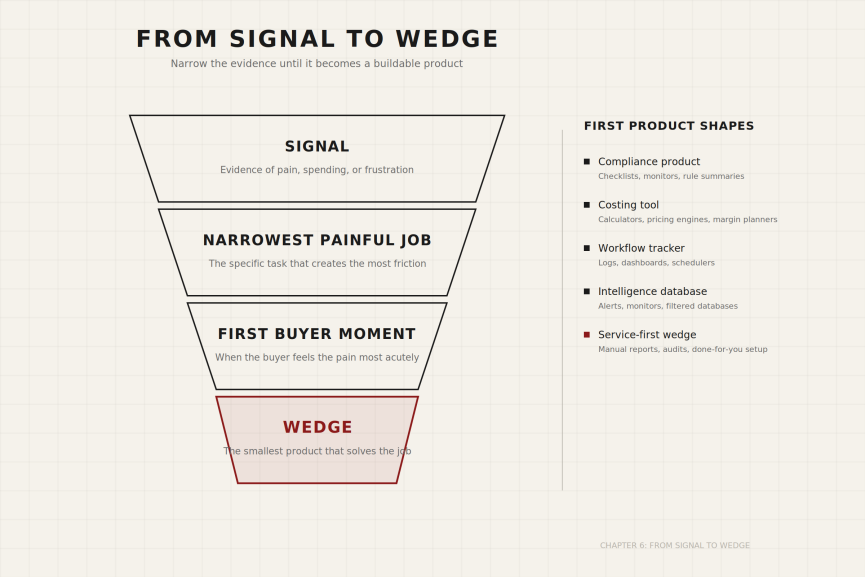
From Signal to Wedge

A pain signal is not a product. It is evidence.

Your job is to turn that evidence into a wedge narrow enough to validate and strong enough to matter.

The move usually looks like this:

1. find the signal
2. identify the narrowest painful job
3. choose the first buyer moment
4. choose the smallest product shape that solves the job



COMMON FIRST PRODUCT SHAPES

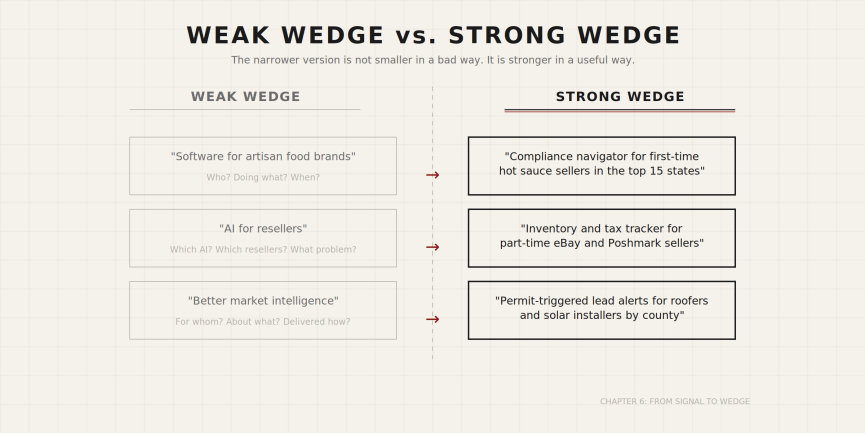
- **Compliance product:** checklists, monitors, filing tools, rule summaries
- **Costing tool:** calculators, pricing engines, margin planners
- **Workflow tracker:** logs, dashboards, trackers, schedulers
- **Searchable intelligence database:** alerts, monitors, filtered databases
- **Service-first wedge:** manual reports, audits, concierge alerts, done-for-you setup

THE WEDGE TEST

A good wedge usually has:

- one obvious buyer
- one painful job
- one trigger moment
- one clear promise

- one believable first version



The narrower version is not smaller in a bad way. It is stronger in a useful way.

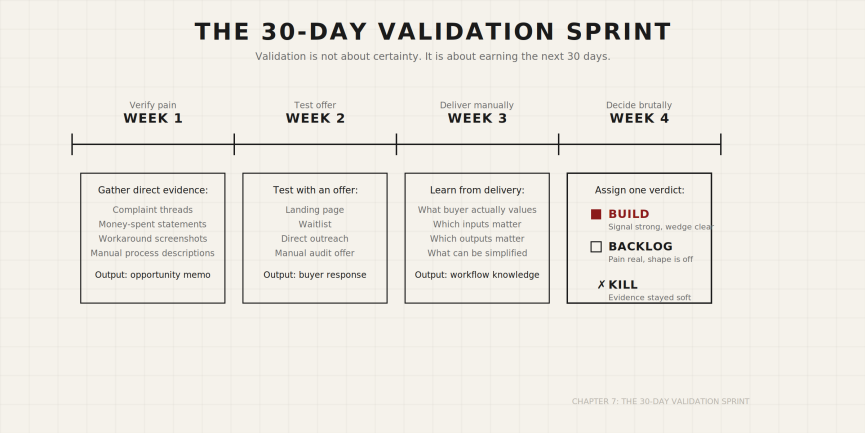
CHAPTER 7

The 30-Day Validation Sprint

Validation is not about certainty. It is about earning the next 30 days.

You are trying to answer four questions quickly:

1. Is the pain real?
2. Is the buyer reachable?
3. Will anyone pay?
4. Is the wedge small enough to ship?



WEEK 1: VERIFY THE PAIN

Gather direct evidence:

- complaint threads
- money-spent statements
- workaround screenshots
- manual process descriptions
- compliance confusion
- repeated buying triggers

Then write a one-page opportunity memo with the buyer, pain, current workaround, trigger moment, wedge, path to money, and main build risk.

WEEK 2: TEST THE OFFER

You do not need a product yet. You need an offer.

Examples:

- a state-specific compliance checklist
- a pricing calculator for custom makers
- a tax-ready inventory export for resellers
- a permit-triggered alert feed for contractors

Test it with a landing page, waitlist, direct outreach, a manual audit offer, or a concierge service.

WEEK 3: DELIVER MANUALLY

This is where many founders cheat. They collect emails and call that validation. Usually it is not.

Manual delivery teaches you:

- what the buyer actually values
- which inputs matter
- which outputs matter

- what can be simplified
- what the software eventually needs to do

A concrete example: if you are testing permit-triggered lead alerts, you do not need a dashboard first. You can manually pull filings for one county, clean them in a spreadsheet, and send a weekly alert email to three contractors. If they reply, ask questions, or ask you to keep sending it, you have signal. If they ignore it, the wedge is weaker than it looked.

If no one wants the manual result, software will not save you.

WEEK 4: DECIDE BRUTALLY

Ask:

- Did I find real pain?
- Did real people respond?
- Did anyone pay, commit, or use the output seriously?
- Did I learn enough to define v1?
- Is this stronger than the next best option?

Then assign one verdict:

- **BUILD** if the signal is strong and the wedge is clear
- **BACKLOG** if the pain is real but timing, access, or shape is off
- **KILL** if the evidence stayed soft or the build path is too heavy

CHAPTER 8

First Customer Before Full Product

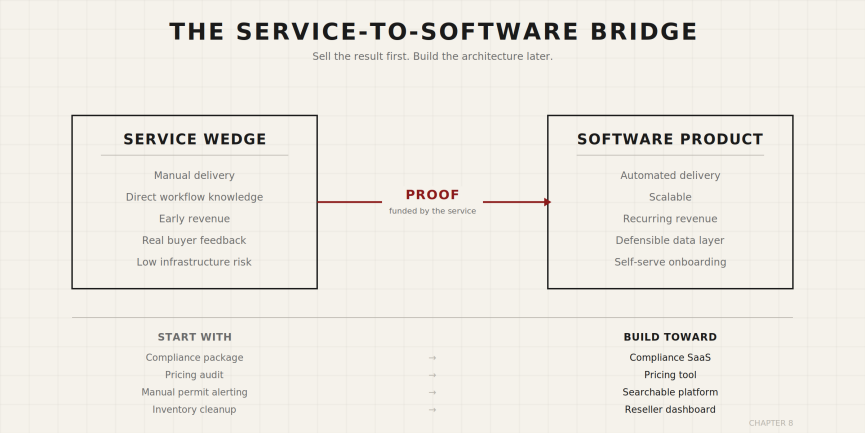
Most solo founders overbuild because software feels like progress. Often it is avoidance.

The fastest way to learn whether a wedge matters is to get a first customer before the product is fully formed.

That customer might be:

- someone who pays for a manual version
- someone who pays for setup or implementation
- someone who buys a report or audit
- someone who commits to a pilot
- someone who hands over real operational data because the result matters

One of the cleanest moves for solo builders is to start with a service-shaped wedge before converting it into software.



This does three things:

1. gets you closer to money faster
2. gives you direct workflow knowledge
3. funds the build instead of waiting for the build to fund itself

A buyer usually cares more about the result than the architecture. Sell the result.

CHAPTER 9

Framework in Action

The point of this section is not volume. It is proof.

These are the kinds of wedges the framework tends to surface when the filters are doing their job. Some have stronger evidence behind them than others. The point is not that each one is a guaranteed winner. The point is that each one shows what a strong opportunity structure looks like.

SCORED OPPORTUNITY CARD

How to read an opportunity through the six filters

SAUCESTACK EXAMPLE CARD

BUYER
First-time hot sauce entrepreneurs

WEDGE
Compliance navigator + label requirement checker

PAIN
State-by-state cottage food confusion, labeling requirements, co-packer uncertainty

FILTER SCORES

Buyer Clarity	5	Can name exact buyer
Pain Severity	4	Delays launch, costs money
Monetization Clarity	4	Checklist upsell, service layer
Build Feasibility	5	Starts as checklist, no infrastructure
Defensibility	3	Moderate: content can be copied
Distribution Realism	4	SEO + communities reachable

TOTAL 25 / 30 ERDICT: BUILD CANDIDA

CHAPTER 9: FRAMEWORK IN ACTION

1. SAUCESTACK

Buyer: First-time hot sauce entrepreneurs

Pain: State-by-state cottage food confusion, labeling requirements, and co-packer uncertainty

Wedge: Compliance navigator plus label requirement checker

Why it works: Clear buyer, urgent trigger, and obvious willingness to pay because mistakes delay launch

What the framework sees: Visible regulatory pain, a strong first-customer moment, and a narrow entry wedge that can begin as a checklist before software deepens

2. FLIPTRACK

Buyer: Part-time and full-time resellers

Pain: Inventory chaos, tax-season panic, unclear profit by item or platform

Wedge: Cross-platform inventory plus tax-ready export

Why it works: Repetitive pain, recurring use, measurable value

What the framework sees: Ugly repeated workflow, obvious cost of mistakes, and a manual bridge that can start with cleanup plus reporting

3. BUILDING PERMIT CROSS-SELL INTELLIGENCE

Buyer: Roofers, solar installers, remodelers, and adjacent home-service operators

Pain: Weak visibility into new jobs at the right time

Wedge: Permit-triggered lead alerts by trade and geography

Why it works: The timing value is easy to explain and easy to sell

What the framework sees: Public-data arbitrage plus strong distribution realism because the trigger is visible and the buyer already pays for worse leads

4. FEDERAL CONTRACTING OPPORTUNITY ENGINE

Buyer: Government contractors, consultants, and capture teams

Pain: Incumbent tools are expensive and government interfaces are painful

Wedge: Better filtering, search, and alerting around solicitations

Why it works: Clear spend, ugly existing experience, high value per win

What the framework sees: A market already paying, a bad existing interface, and a buyer who can justify spend when signal quality is higher

5. CRAFTLEDGER

Buyer: Leather crafters and commission-based makers

Pain: Underpricing labor, weak quoting discipline, poor materials tracking

Wedge: Project costing and pricing calculator

Why it works: Small pricing improvements create immediate ROI

What the framework sees: A narrow buyer, recurring pain, and a wedge that can be sold as a tool, worksheet, or service before it becomes software

The common pattern should be obvious by now. The strongest opportunities are usually not the most glamorous. They are the ones where pain is visible, the trigger is real, and the first version can solve one painful job without pretending to be a whole company on day one.

CHAPTER 10

What to Build Next

The final decision is not, "What sounds best?"

It is, "What deserves the next 30 days more than the alternatives?"

Choose the opportunity that best combines:

- strongest score
- clearest wedge
- fastest path to proof
- best fit with your actual strengths
- lowest risk of dragging you into a swamp before first revenue

The best next build is often not the biggest market. It is the cleanest entry point.

Do not let two promising ideas advance at the same time unless one is clearly a sidecar asset. Parallel idea pursuit feels productive. Usually it is focus leakage.

Build one. Backlog one. Kill the rest.

That is enough.

CHAPTER 11

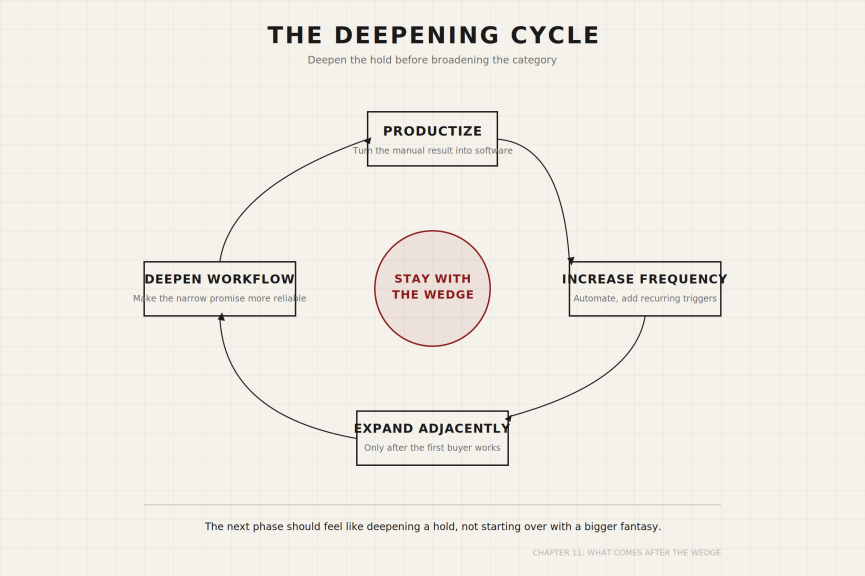
What Comes After the Wedge

If the wedge works, the next job is not to explode the scope. It is to deepen the proof.

The first thing you should do after a promising 30-day sprint is get closer to repeated use. Can the buyer come back? Can the output become recurring? Can the same narrow promise be delivered with less manual work and more reliability? Can you improve the workflow without blurring the wedge?

That usually means one of four moves:

- productize the manual result
- increase frequency or automation
- expand to adjacent buyers only after the first buyer is working
- deepen the workflow before broadening the category



This is where a lot of builders relapse. They survive the idea trap, prove a narrow wedge, then immediately try to turn it into a broad platform because the early signal feels like permission to expand.

It usually is not.

The wedge earned the next phase because it was specific. Keep respecting that. Stay with the buyer. Stay with the trigger. Stay with the painful job. Make the recurring version better before you start imagining the category diagram.

The next phase should feel like deepening a hold, not starting over with a bigger fantasy.

Conclusion

This framework sounds ruthless because it is.

That is also why it is useful.

The hard part is not understanding the filters. The hard part is using them against ideas you actually like. Killing weak ideas is emotionally expensive because weak ideas are rarely worthless. They are usually just mistimed, under-shaped, under-validated, or not strong enough to deserve the next few months of your life.

That is what makes discipline difficult. You are not usually cutting obvious trash. You are cutting things that could maybe become something later. But "maybe later" is exactly how builders get trapped in soft conviction and scattered attention.

This book is not here to make you feel like you have more options.

It is here to make you choose better.

You do not need a hundred ideas. You need one strong wedge, one real buyer, one believable path to money, and the discipline to ignore everything else until the market answers you.

That is enough to build something real.

APPENDIX A

Pattern Library

These are shorter opportunity patterns worth studying. They are not the main proof section. They are pattern exercises.

HIVESTACK

Buyer: Sideline beekeepers and small commercial operators

Pain: Colony loss, treatment timing, weak profitability tracking

Wedge: Hive log plus treatment scheduler plus simple economics tracker

LIQUOR LICENSE OPENING ALERTS

Buyer: Restaurant vendors, equipment suppliers, POS sellers, insurers

Pain: Missing the earliest buying window for new operators

Wedge: License approval alert feed

CFPB COMPLAINT INTELLIGENCE

Buyer: Consumers, analysts, financial marketers, and reputation operators

Pain: Complaint data exists but is difficult to interpret at decision level

Wedge: Searchable complaint trends and reputation monitoring

RESTAURANT INSPECTION CRISIS ALERTS

Buyer: Restaurant operators, consultants, and reputation managers

Pain: Inspection failures become public quickly and damage revenue

Wedge: Alerting plus rapid-response checklist

CONTRACTOR LICENSE VIOLATION MONITOR

Buyer: Contractors, insurers, sureties, and compliance service providers

Pain: Disciplinary actions and licensing lapses are hard to track across jurisdictions

Wedge: Monitoring plus alerting plus referral hooks

SMALL-BATCH PRODUCTION TRACKER

Buyer: Artisan food and handmade-goods producers

Pain: Spreadsheet-heavy batch logs, poor traceability, weak costing discipline

Wedge: Batch management for one production type first

ARTISAN SUPPLIER INTELLIGENCE DIRECTORY

Buyer: Makers and small-batch producers

Pain: Supplier quality, lead time, price, and trust are fragmented and anecdotal

Wedge: Searchable, vetted supplier database by niche

UCC FILING LEAD INTELLIGENCE

Buyer: Insurers, lenders, equipment vendors, and service providers

Pain: Weak visibility into businesses that just financed assets and now need adjacent services

Wedge: Newly financed business trigger intelligence

COMPLIANCE LAUNCH PLANNER

Buyer: Niche operators moving from hobby to business in regulated categories

Pain: No structured path across entity setup, compliance, pricing, and first sales

Wedge: Vertical-specific launch planner with templates and state guidance

APPENDIX B

Opportunity Scorecard

Rate each idea from **1 to 5** on:

- buyer clarity
- pain severity
- monetization clarity
- build feasibility
- defensibility
- distribution realism

INTERPRETATION

- **26–30:** strong build candidate
- **21–25:** good candidate, but test the wedge before committing deeply
- **16–20:** backlog or tighten the wedge
- **15 and below:** kill unless new evidence changes the picture

APPENDIX C

One-Page Opportunity Worksheet

For every serious opportunity, fill this out before building:

Working name: _____

Buyer: _____

Pain: _____

Current workaround: _____

Trigger moment: _____

Wedge: _____

Why now: _____

Path to money: _____

_____

Fastest way to test: _____

_____

Main risk: _____

_____

Build / Backlog / Kill: _____

_____

If you cannot complete this in plain English, the idea is still too fuzzy.